

Online Interactive Game-Based Learning in High School History Education: Impact on Educational Effectiveness and Student Motivation

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Abstract

Online games have become a part of our modern life. They are especially attractive to children and teenagers. A series of studies also show that e-learning not only triggers users' intrinsic motivation, but also arouses peer cooperation and coordination. As for underachievers, it boosts their learning motivation and academic performance. So, the research applied Interactive Game-based Learning System (IGLS) to junior high history teaching as an ancillary tool to enhance users' learning motivation and academic performance. After a four-week experiment conducted on eleven students, the paired sample t test analysis showed considerably impact on experimental group to significance .05. Besides, questionnaires exhibited that IGLS not only magnetized over ninety percent of students' participation but invigorated their learning will. The research presents positive result on enhancing students' learning motivation and academic performance.

Keywords: Online game; game-based learning; history education

1. Introduction

With rapid growth in information communication technology, online games like Nintendo Wii、XBOX Kinect、SONY PS3 have gradually become part of people's life in recent years. It is believed that digital games, as a catalyst, can be very useful teaching media. For this reason, teachers must elevate students' learning ability and knowledge through temporary assistance like information technology. To teachers and students, the meaning of this incoming digital trend counts for more challenges than opportunities. History, a subject about facts, should also be inextricably linked to digital world. Being a junior high history teacher, the researcher found that it would be better to use a lively way—learning by playing—we can use some digital assistance to arouse students' learning motivation and academic performance.

Moreover, traditionally teacher-centered didactic instruction is progressively substituted by student-centered various interactive learning patterns [1]. The innovating digital learning which claims for enhancing learners' motivation and initiative exploration is available to all. Terms like E-learning, U-learning, Digital Game-based Learning (DGBL) gradually represent information technology integrated into teaching in school.

DGBL was first proposed by Marc Prensky in 2001[1]. Through digital games, learners obtain sense of achievement in solving problems and dealing with challenges. Digital game based learning takes both entertainment and education into consideration. In Prensky's opinion, digital game based learning will be the main learning pattern in the 21st century, the traditional learning style such as emphasizing reading and writing is going to be replaced[1]. Online games stand for part of teenagers' culture, so it's undoubtedly inevitable to integrate it into school education [10].

Moreover, successful learning definitely needs motivation [9]. Learning motivation is the key factor whether digital game based learning and web base learning community work or not. Munn et al. defined that motivation, as a sort of intrinsic power such as interest, attitude and desire, can influence personal behavior [16]. On the other hand, Keller regarded motivation as people's choice of experiences and goals, and how they make efforts to achieve them [17]. Besides, Reilly, Lewis & Tanner considered motivation to be the power inside oneself [18]. Of all digital learning motivation theory, Keller's ARCS theory is the most universal one. The theory is composed of four aspects: attention, relevance, confidence and satisfaction [17]. Taran placed specific emphasis on attention, so he promoted ten skills for maintaining learners' online learning attention to strengthen motivation [19]. That proves the importance of motivation to academic performance. Paras.B & Bizzocchi.J [20] combined ARCS theory with Csikszentmihalyi's Flow theory [21] because they thought that a good digital game design immerses learners in games, then brings about effective learning process.

Games, one of the oldest learning methods, are part of human cognition development. They have positive effect on learning basic cognition operation [6], understanding complex grammar structure [7],

and abstract thinking [2]. According to Vygotsky, learning by playing helped promote Zone of Proximal Development (ZPD) [2]. In Bruner's research, it indicates that games can adjust teaching for both fast learners and slow ones to attain the spirit of spiral curriculum [8]. Cheng and Chen[3] also found that peer cooperation and coordination through digital interactive games enriched learners' learning motivation and academic performance. Prensky, a game designer, pointed out the integration of games and learning will change from the traditional idea "learning is depressing" to "learning by playing, learning through playing" [1]. To realize this ideal purpose, letting students learn actively will make the process of learning become more and more interesting.

After Lippitt invented the term learning community [12], most scholars and experts generally acknowledge that it is characterized by learning by sharing [13]. Web base learning community, online virtual space, means a group of learners form common learning culture in which they brainstorm, make efforts and understand each other [14]. By integrating scholars' viewpoints of online learning community, Wang offered a clear definition: web base learning community is a kind of computer-mediated communication which includes sharing ideas, knowledge, experience and information, forming common purpose, investigating, and enhancing knowledge and ability. Within the atmosphere of support, care, openness and compliance, learners can challenge his/her own belief, value, knowledge and experience. Furthermore, learners enhance his/ her knowledge and ability as a result of introspection. The learning culture figures that learning relies on social interaction which derives from personal active communication, sharing and investigation [15].

Digital learning can enhance students' motivation except for focusing too much on playing games instead of learning itself. In Mitchell and Savill-Smith's study, if digital learning turns into games addiction, game type learning will brings down learners' motivation [4]. So, Johnson and Johnson propound to take interest, collaboration, feedback and assessment into consideration [5]. Prensky featured six key elements to choose or develop digital game based learning patterns: (1) rules (2) goals or objectives (3) outcomes and feedback (4) conflict, competition, challenge and opposition (5) interaction (6) representation and story. For teachers, these ideas are great references to establish or adopt digital game patterns [1].

To put these ideals into reality, an experiment of IGLS was conducted for a month, surveys toward participants and interviews were both applied. Employing IGLS as an ancillary tool in learning Taiwan history, the researcher looks forward to enhancing learners' motivation and academic performance by online community learning mechanism like group competition. The research

enables learners to form community through free grouping, and members of the group probe into the knowledge of history and share information with each other in chat rooms. Additionally, they create the sense of collaboration as well as knowledge sharing.

2. IGLS for History educational games design

2.1 Interactive Game-based Learning System, IGLS

The IGLS system is composed of three elements, which are quiz game module, item generation module, and learning management module. The system not only enables students to review their learning, but also to compete against other participants. To increase the randomness of quizzes, the system offers three types of item generation algorithms, including multiple choice with random options, match items, and random argument computational problems. In doing so, it is expected to effectively attract students' attention. Furthermore, the learning management module allow students and teachers to monitor the learning process. This pedagogical experiment is a design for evaluating students' motivation and academic performance [11].

2.2 Game design

IGLS's user interface includes manager (teacher) and player (learner). Players can register and, after checked by managers, choose their own courses. They can also pace themselves to choose stand-alone or online version. After signing in, players can select units and start a game as long as both sides have equal team members (2 vs. 2 or 3 vs. 3...etc.).

Both teams have one hundred hit points. After showing randomly selected questions, players attack any opponent or choose compound attack. If the opponent gets the answer wrong, its hit points will diminish. On the contrary, if it gets the answer right, the opponent's hit points reduce. Game is over when one loses all hit points.

Players review records in the form of a chart which shows each unit's score. Furthermore, they can evaluate themselves. Besides, they create the sense of collaboration as well as knowledge sharing. Managers can check learners' performance by viewing each record, and then make adjustments.

2.3 Teaching materials

The experimental group learned about Taiwan history within games. IGLS includes context of seven graders' sociology textbook "Taiwan history (Vol.1) , and the contents are prehistory, international competition, Cheng's governance and earlier stage of Ching dynasty's occupation

3. Experiment design and result

3.1 Experiment design

The study took sample of thirty students from Taichung Municipal Dongshan Senior High Class 719. Based on the pretest average score 90, nineteen students who got higher scores are in the control group (high achievers), whereas another eleven students who got lower scores are in the experimental group (low achievers).

A pretest on Taiwan history (Vol. 1) was conducted a week before the experiment began. In the first week, I took students were taken to the computer classroom, introduced to the system and instructed the way to use it. When the experiment commenced, I reminded them to use it after school every week. The experiment lasted for a month, and students can use the system wherever Internet is accessible. In the fourth week, a survey was done to the experimental group. After the experiment ended (the fifth week), a post test was conducted to all students.

To find out whether there are remarkable improvements in academic performance or not, paired sample t test analysis of the pretest and post test of Taiwan history (Vol. 1) on both groups was conducted. Thus, the pretest result of Taiwan history (Vol. 1) is used as covariance, learning method as independent variable, the post test of Taiwan history (Vol. 1) as dependent variable, to determine if the factors indicate significant influence on academic performance. Consequently, by analyzing experimental group's survey, students' opinion and their intension to participate were identified.

3.2 Taiwan history (Vol. 1) achievement test

In order to evaluate the academic performance between experimental and control group, the research drew up test questions about Taiwan history (Vol. 1) which came from both IGLS's contents and Taiwan history textbook 1. The sample contains four hundred multiple-choice questions.

3.3 comparison for students' achievement

Table 1 contains statistics of the experiment which is conducted by unequal grouping's pretest and post test. In order to examine the improvement between pretest and post test on both groups, paired sample t test is used. In Table 2, significant progression in each group can be discovered. Furthermore, the experimental group students made better improvement than the control group (-7.27 to -1.68). With assistance of IGLS, the experimental group students demonstrated level of significance at .05($P=.010$), while the control group students indicated insignificant progression ($P=.061$). As a result, the system indeed promotes students' academic

performance in Taiwan history.

Table 1 Descriptive statistics for achievement

		Mean ^a	N ^a	SD ^a	SEM ^a
Control-group ^a	Pretest1 ^a	94.5263 ^a	19 ^a	3.04354 ^a	.69824 ^a
	Posttest1 ^a	96.2105 ^a	19 ^a	2.57291 ^a	.59027 ^a
Experimental group ^a	Pretest2 ^a	84.1818 ^a	11 ^a	3.51620 ^a	1.06017 ^a
	Posttest2 ^a	91.4545 ^a	11 ^a	10.04354 ^a	3.02824 ^a

Table 2 Paired sample t test analysis for achievement

		Pooled variance ^a					t ^a	DF ^a	Significance (two-tailed) ^a
		Mean ^a	SD ^a	SEM ^a	95% CI ^a				
					Low ^a	High ^a			
Control group ^a	pretest-posttest ^a	-1.68421 ^a	3.66746 ^a	.84137 ^a	-3.45187 ^a	.08345 ^a	-2.002 ^a	18 ^a	.061 ^a
Experimental group ^a	pretest-posttest ^a	-7.27273 ^a	7.55104 ^a	2.27672 ^a	-12.34558 ^a	-2.19987 ^a	-3.194 ^a	10 ^a	.010 ^a

3.4 Questionnaire result for IGLS

The research applies Likert's Five-Point scale to find out experimental group students' opinion and motivation of using IGLS. Strongly agree gets five points, agree gets four, neutral gets three, disagree gets two and strongly disagree gets one point. In accordance with the function and design, the researcher discussed and analyzed with professor and program designers to keep content validity.

To understand the function of IGLS and the motivation it triggers, the research surveyed the experimental group students in the fourth week. The result can be future's reference to the design of interface or the selection of the game platform. The research uses Likert's Five-Point scale: strongly agree gets five points, agree gets four, neutral gets three, disagree gets two and strongly disagree gets one point. And the whole survey is divided into three parts: interface, function and motivation.

The result is as follows: Strongly agree (61.82 %), Agree (27.27 %), neutral (10.91%), Disagree (0%), and Strongly disagree (0%), with a grand mean of 4.51. Over ninety percent students approve of the system's attraction to their participation and intension shown as table3 to table5.

Table 3 Satisfaction of IGLS's interface

	Assessment Score ^a					Mean ^a	SD ^a
	5 ^a	4 ^a	3 ^a	2 ^a	1 ^a		
1.The interface is easy to handle.	63.64%	36.36%	0.00%	0.00%	0.00%	4.64 ^a	0.505 ^a
2.The content is clearly expressed.	72.73%	27.27%	0.00%	0.00%	0.00%	4.73 ^a	0.467 ^a
3.The buttons are easy to click on.	81.82%	18.18%	0.00%	0.00%	0.00%	4.82 ^a	0.405 ^a
4.Convenience of the design	63.64%	27.27%	9.09%	0.00%	0.00%	4.55 ^a	0.688 ^a

Table 4 Satisfaction of IGLS's functionality

	Assessment Score					Mean	SD
	5	4	3	2	1		
1.The records do help me with learning.	63.64%	27.27%	9.09%	0.00%	0.00%	4.55	0.688
2.The group competition help me with learning.	63.64%	27.27%	9.09%	0.00%	0.00%	4.55	0.688
3.The online version help me with learning.	54.55%	45.45%	0.00%	0.00%	0.00%	4.55	0.522
4.The message board makes communication easier for me.	36.36%	36.36%	27.27%	0.00%	0.00%	4.09	0.831
5.I can handle the situation in group competition.	63.64%	18.18%	18.18%	0.00%	0.00%	4.45	0.820

Table 5 Satisfaction of IGLS's motivation improvement

	Assessment Score					Mean	SD
	5	4	3	2	1		
1.The game arouses my participation.	63.64%	27.27%	9.09%	0.00%	0.00%	4.55	0.688
2.The game improves my performance.	63.64%	36.36%	0.00%	0.00%	0.00%	4.64	0.505
3.The game eases my pressure in learning.	72.73%	18.18%	9.09%	0.00%	0.00%	4.64	0.674
4. The game attracts my interest in history.	54.55%	27.27%	18.18%	0.00%	0.00%	4.36	0.809
5.I think the system is suitable for learning history.	54.55%	27.27%	18.18%	0.00%	0.00%	4.36	0.809

4. Conclusion

According to digital game based learning theory, the research used IGLS as an ancillary tool in seventh graders' history teaching. In the end of the experiment, the following three aspects were examed: the improvement in academic performance, increase in motivation, and positive learning attitude. First IGLS benefits academic performance in junior high history learning. Second IGLS especially provides low achievers with confidence and positive attitude. Third IGLS arouses conspicuous improvement in both motivation and concentration. In conclusion, IGLS has positive effects on history learning, thus, it can be of assistance in history teaching.

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